

FIELD NOTES ON QUIET PLACES

An original short collection by Common Room Studio

CC0 - made for this demonstration collection, 2026

I. THE WINDOW

There is a tree outside the window that I have been meaning to identify for three years. Each spring I make a small promise to find its name. Each summer the promise disappears behind the leaves.

Today I put down the book about trees and looked at the tree itself. A branch moved. Another did not. In the space between them was a piece of pale sky, no larger than an envelope.

Knowing a name is one way of paying attention. Looking is another. I am trying to make room for both.

The morning continued without an announcement. Someone wheeled a bicycle through the courtyard. A kettle switched itself off. The world offered its ordinary sounds and asked nothing of me.

I wrote down: a quiet place is not always a place without noise.

II. THE PATH

The path begins behind a gate that no longer closes. A stone holds it open, though the stone has been there so long that its purpose now seems ceremonial.

In the first hundred steps, the town is still with you. There is the road, the school, the delivery van reversing. Then the path turns, and the sounds fold into one another until they become a kind of weather.

I used to walk this way to get somewhere. Now I sometimes walk to the bend and return. There is nothing at the bend. That is part of its appeal.

On a wet afternoon I found a leaf pressed flat against a stone. Its veins were so fine that I had to crouch to see them. While I was looking, someone passed and said hello. We shared the small embarrassment of having interrupted nothing important.

Later I wondered how much of a life is made from things that seem unimportant at the time.

III. THE SHORE

The water was the colour of an old spoon. Across it, a low line of land appeared and disappeared in the mist.

I sat on a wall that had been repaired with three different kinds of stone. The repairs were not hidden. Each had its own colour, its own idea of a straight edge. Together they held up the wall.

A person came down to the water with an empty bucket. They filled it, stood for a moment, and carried it away. I do not know why. There are still many things I do not need to know.

The tide moved a small piece of wood up the beach, then down again. For ten minutes it seemed to make no progress. Then I looked away and the wood was gone.

IV. THE ROOM

At the end of the day, the room has changed. The furniture is where it was, but the light has moved everything a little to the left.

There is a book open on the table. There is a cup beside it. Neither is waiting in any dramatic sense. They are simply available.

I like that word. Available. Something offered without insistence.

Perhaps that is what a library should be: not a list of things to finish, but a room full of things that are available. A story for one kind of afternoon. A song for another. A window when the words will not come.

I close the notebook. Outside, the unnamed tree is becoming a shape against the sky. Tomorrow I may look up its name. Tonight, it is enough to notice that it is there.

END

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